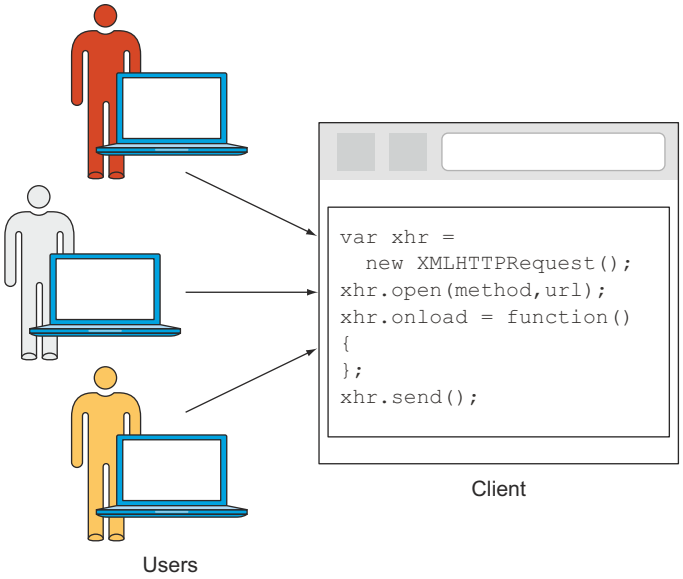


Figure 3.11 Multiple users interacting with a website's client code

BROWSER

The client code runs inside a web browser. The CORS spec calls the web browser a user agent, but we'll refer to it as the web browser. Just like the ATM, the browser is a trusted intermediary, and plays an active role in a CORS request in two ways:

- The browser adds additional information to the request so that the server can identify the client.
- The browser interprets the server's response and decides whether to send the request to the client or to return an error.

If the browser didn't do these things, a client could send any request to the server, and the protection introduced by the browser's same-origin policy would be broken. The browser ensures that both the client and the server play by the rules of CORS.

SERVER

The server is the destination of the CORS request. It's the bank account in the ATM analogy. The server stores the data that the client wants, and it has the final say as to whether the CORS request is allowed or not.

Now that you know who is involved in a CORS request, let's take a look at how they all work together.

3.3.2 Lifecycle of a CORS request

A full end-to-end CORS request flow is shown in figure 3.12. Although technically the client code runs inside the browser, figure 3.12 separates the client from the browser to make it easier to envision the flow. The steps in a CORS request, illustrated in the figure, are: